The Everyday Abilities Cheat Sheet

Plain words for daily activities, and what to note under each.

“Daily activities.” “Transfers.” “Baseline.” They sound like words from a chart, and they describe Dad getting dressed and getting up from his chair. Here are eighteen of them in plain terms, with what to note under each.

The words are for describing Dad's days and for following a conversation. Assessing is someone else's job.

Everyday activities

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks of everyday life: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, transferring to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which ones Dad does on his own. For most, “on his own” may be the whole note.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

The everyday tasks: housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing and cleaning up after meals, shopping, using the telephone, caring for pets, and responding to emergency alerts such as fire alarms. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each one now, and roughly since when.

Bathing

Washing oneself by sponge bath or in the bathtub or shower. [2]

WRITE DOWN His usual routine, and anything he uses.

Dressing

Putting on and taking off all items of clothing, along with any braces, fasteners or artificial limbs. [2]

WRITE DOWN What he does himself, and anything that takes longer than it used to.

Eating

In an assessment, using utensils to bring food and drink to the mouth and swallow it once the meal is in front of the person. Cooking is listed separately, under preparing meals. [3] [1]

WRITE DOWN What an ordinary day's meals look like. Questions about appetite or swallowing go on the list for his doctor.

Toileting and continence

Toileting is using the toilet. Continence is the ability to control bowel and bladder functions or, when that isn't possible, to manage the personal hygiene that goes with it. [1] [2]

WRITE DOWN Only what Dad chooses to tell you. Anything he raises goes on the list for his doctor.

Transferring (transfers)

Moving into and out of a bed, chair or wheelchair. [2]

WRITE DOWN How he gets up from his chair and out of bed, and what he puts a hand on.

Mobility

Moving around. It's on the Administration for Community Living's list of what personal care helps with, next to bathing, dressing and eating. [2]

WRITE DOWN How he gets around the house and beyond it, and anything he uses.

How help is described

Independent

Doing the activity by oneself, with no assistance from a helper. The assessment form home health clinicians complete adds that an activity may be done with or without assistive devices. [3]

WRITE DOWN “On his own,” and what he uses, if anything.

Cueing or standing by

A helper gives verbal cues or a steadying touch while the person does the activity. The form's own phrase is “supervision or touching assistance.” [3]

WRITE DOWN Anything where someone reminds him or stays close, and who.

Usual performance

How a person usually manages. It's what clinicians completing that form are told to record for each activity. [3]

WRITE DOWN An ordinary week, not his best day or the day he had a cold.

People and services

Caregiver

A family member, partner, friend or neighbor who helps care for someone living at home. [4]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who does something for Dad, and what each one does.

Care manager (case manager)

A professional, usually with a background in counseling, social work or a related healthcare field, trained to assess a family's individual situation. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family has talked with one, and the questions you'd bring.

Skilled care

Nursing care, such as help with medications and caring for wounds, and therapies such as occupational, speech, respiratory and physical therapy. It usually requires a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. [2]

WRITE DOWN Any nursing or therapy Dad already has, who provides it, and since when. “None” is an answer.

On the page

Baseline

A dated description of how Dad manages now, kept to compare against later. The word is the Family Care Roadmap's own.

WRITE DOWN Today's date at the top, before anything else.

His own account, and the family's

Two separate records. His own account is what Dad says he can do and where a hand is welcome. A family observation is something one of you saw happen. AARP's planning guide says a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care. [6]

WRITE DOWN What he said, as he said it. Then what was seen, the date, and who saw it.

Medication list

An up-to-date list of all his medicines: prescription drugs, over-the-counter medicines, vitamins, other nutritional products and herbal remedies. [7]

WRITE DOWN Where the current list is kept, its date, and who updates it.

Reassessment

A professional looking at Dad's situation again at a later date. When that should happen is for his doctor and the other professionals who know him to say. This is the Roadmap's word too.

WRITE DOWN The question to bring them: when should we look at this again?

What this sheet doesn't do

It gives you words. It doesn't say which of them apply to Dad, or whether he needs any help at all. Those are questions for his doctor and the other professionals who know him.

Ready for the next step?

You have the words now, and something to note under each. The care interview puts them to work: it asks about each area of Dad's daily life in order, in plain language, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The definitions come from the sources below, in our plain wording. “Baseline” and “reassessment” are the Family Care Roadmap's own words, and the notes on what to write down are ours.

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Outcome and Assessment Information Set Version E1 (OASIS-E1), All Items
4. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
6. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiver's Guide to Medications and Aging

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